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Welch tries to contain fallout

Illinois House speaker holds outreach meetings over handling of Benton harassment allegations

By Rick Pearson
and Jeremy Gerner
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Illinois House Speaker Emanuel “Chris” Welch, seeking to contain political fallout over his handling of sexual harassment complaints against former state Rep. Harry Benton, held outreach meetings with Democratic caucuses Tuesday, telling members that delays

in taking action against Benton stemmed from the wishes of a now-former Benton staffer who first reported the allegations three years ago.

Welch said his office waited three months after the female staffer notified his office of a lengthy list of harassment allegations before taking any action, because the young woman said she wanted the speaker’s office to wait until she had

left her job, according to several Democratic House members who spoke on condition of anonymity to avoid repercussions.

But the former Benton staffer told the Tribune on Tuesday she did not recall telling the speaker’s office to delay taking action and, just weeks after filing her initial report of harassment allegations against the former Plainfield Democrat, she told the speaker’s office about additional inappropriate comments she experienced with Benton. She has said Welch took no action on her complaints.

Welch also told lawmakers he had acted to respect the former staffer’s wishes not to “pursue” action against Benton. But she said that was in reference to her rejecting Welch’s office’s push for her to file a report with the legislative inspector general’s office. She has said she preferred that Welch’s office handle the matter internally and further stated that she didn’t want other women to face harassment from Benton in the future.

APPOINTMENT: Democrats pick Jessica Dixon Heitman, late U.S. senator’s granddaughter, to replace ex-state Rep. Harry Benton. **Page A4**

“I genuinely, to the best of my knowledge, I don’t remember saying, ‘Wait till I left,’” the former staffer, who left Benton’s office after only six months on the job, said Tuesday of her prior dealings with Welch’s office.

“I was very anxious at the time. It was very stressful, my departure from the office. But I do not recall saying, ‘Wait to take action,’” she

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WHALES’ ODYSSEY TO CHICAGO

A beluga whale named Sierra is transported by a group of experts from Marineland and several U.S. aquariums onto a truck at Marineland in Niagara Falls, Ontario, on Monday. Sierra is one of four belugas brought to the Shedd Aquarium from Canada as part of an international effort to rescue 30 belugas from a closed marine park. **Chicagoland, Page A3**

CARLOS OSORIO/THE CANADIAN PRESS

Attacks weigh on diplomacy in Mideast

Ceasefire slides further away as US, Iran battle over Strait of Hormuz

By Jon Gambrell
and Munir Ahmed
ASSOCIATED PRESS

ISLAMABAD — A 10th straight day of attacks between the United States and Iran across the Middle East on Tuesday overshadowed diplomatic efforts in Pakistan to salvage an interim ceasefire deal that collapsed earlier this month as the two countries battled for control of a waterway vital to world energy supplies.

Iranian Interior Minister Eskandar Momeni visited Pakistan, a key mediator in the conflict that is seeking to rejuvenate diplomacy, but it was unclear what new arrangement might be reached to end the war. Speaking from the Oval Office, President Donald Trump gave a dim view on possible talks, saying the U.S. had “no interest in meeting.”

Shipping through the Strait of Hormuz has largely stalled, and as the fight for control over the waterway intensifies, both sides have targeted civilian infrastructure in the region relied on by millions of people.

A barrage of U.S. strikes hasn’t compelled Tehran to loosen its grip on the strait, through which about one-fifth of the world’s crude oil and natural gas was shipped before the war. The U.S. continued its airstrikes on the Islamic Republic early Tuesday, and Iran attacked a tanker in the strait, forcing the crew to abandon the ship.

Iran also kept up attacks against U.S. allies in the region. Sirens in Bahrain and Kuwait warned residents on Tuesday afternoon of incoming projectiles.

In the Red Sea, Iran-backed

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COST OF IRAN WAR: Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth said the conflict has cost \$37.5 billion so far. **Nation & World, Page B4**

ICE detains CPS custodian at check-in

Advocates say agency targeting people at routine appointments

By Kate Perez
and Laura Rodríguez Presa
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

A 13-year-old Venezuelan boy tried to stay calm as he translated the words his mother could not understand during their immigration check-in on Friday morning.

Standing inside a small room in an Immigration and Customs Enforcement office in downtown

Chicago, he began to cry after he was told to tell his mother that the entire family was being detained. His father, Josue Pire Hidalgo, had been taken aside and sent to the ICE processing center earlier that day.

“He was the one translating because my English is bad,” said the boy’s mother, the wife of Pire Hidalgo. “When my son heard that I was detained, he became very nervous. He started crying.”

When an interpreter was eventually called because the boy could no longer translate, the woman was told that she and her children

would be released because their 6-year-old daughter has asthma and relies on daily medication, but the mother would be required to wear an ankle monitor.

Now, a North Side community is rallying around Pire Hidalgo, a Chicago Public Schools custodian and father of two, whose arrest comes as immigration enforcement has surged across the Midwest this summer. Attorneys and immigrant advocates say ICE has increasingly begun to target people during routine immigra-



Josue Pire Hidalgo

tion check-ins, in criminal courthouse parking lots and during traffic stops — a shift from the large-scale workplace raids and neighborhood operations that dominated headlines a year ago.

CPS said in a statement to the Tribune that the district ensures that all new hires hold legal authorization to work in the U.S. in accordance with federal, state and municipal laws, and that it also “provides support

See **ICE** on Page A2

INSIDE

‘The best stadium in all of football’

Northwestern coaches toured the new Ryan Field on Tuesday. They were impressed, and were careful to note the Wildcats need to put a good product on the field to make the stadium come to life. **Sports**

Getting to know the city’s ‘Donut King’

Buritt Bulloch, who turns 88 this year, can still be found making doughnuts in the front window of Old Fashioned Donuts in Chicago’s Roseland neighborhood. **Food & Health**



Mayra Macías, an independent candidate for the 4th Congressional District seat, speaks to the media along with fellow candidate, Ald. Byron Sigcho-Lopez, 25th, following a Board of Elections hearing on Tuesday, where Macías and Sigcho-Lopez were ordered off the ballot. **ANTONIO PEREZ/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

ELECTION 2026 4TH CONGRESSIONAL DISTRICT 2 progressive, independent candidates kicked off ballot

Challenges came from people tied to García and handpicked successor

By Olivia Olander
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Two progressive, independent candidates for the 4th Congressional District should not appear on the General Election ballot in November, the Illinois State Board of Elections voted Tuesday.

The board voted without opposition that Mayra Macías and the other hopeful, Ald. Byron Sig-

cho-Lopez, 25th, should not be on the ballot for the Southwest Side and west suburban district because they didn’t collect the requisite number of valid signatures. The decision came after challenges from people with ties to U.S. Rep. Jesús “Chuy” García, who is retiring, and Patty García, his handpicked successor.

“It is a sad day for democracy when the two Latino candidates, that are running as independents because we were not allowed to run as Democrats, are kicked off

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